

Mind, Mood, and the Scroll



BIG IDEA Social media affects sleep, mood, self-image, relationships and attention, for better and worse, and research is still working out how much and for whom. Compulsive use is a pattern you can notice and change, and help exists.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

REVIEW STATUS REQUIRES REVIEW BY A SCHOOL COUNSELOR OR CLINICIAN BEFORE CLASSROOM USE. Written 2026-10-05, not yet reviewed by anyone outside the author.

COUNSELOR HEADS-UP FIRST + OPT-OUT PLAN Counselor told 5 school days ahead; know your self-harm protocol and 988. Family note home first. No formal opt-out, but one is honored (alternate: the Two-Week Experiment card with the counselor). Teach mid-week.

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Say: “Hackles up? Notice what the feed does to your mood, your sleep and your time. If you feel worse after, or cannot stop when you want to, that is data. This is no lecture on how bad screens are. Many people find connection, creativity and support online. For some people, at some times, it also affects mood, sleep, how they feel about their lives, friendships, and how well they can stop. Researchers are still working out how large the effects are and for whom. Today you map them. You do not judge them.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *Impact Map*

- 1 (1 min) Four domains:** Sleep, Mood and self-image, Relationships, Attention and control. A doctor or counselor decides whether someone has a health condition.
- 2 (4 min) Fill in the map.** Each group takes one fictional vignette: the effect; what makes it worse; one adjustment; the signal that means “talk to someone,” and to whom. The Mood vignette ends with a character who “stops answering friends and says nothing will get better”: mark it GET HELP TODAY and name an adult and 988.
- 3 (2 min) Share-out.** One finding per group. Sleep, mood, comparison, belonging and control affect each other.
- 4 (1 min) Two-Week Experiment.** Privately pick one adjustment (no phone in bed, muted notifications, an app-free evening) and one person to check in with. Defense Plan line: “My well-being setting is ____.” Results stay private.

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Pause when sleep, mood or control starts slipping. Check which feature or habit is pulling you, and try one adjustment. Tell a trusted adult or the counselor if it keeps happening or you feel hopeless. Help exists: 988, the counselor, a doctor. It is never your fault that apps are built to hold attention.”

Hand signal: Hackles up (hand brushed up the neck, optional). Post it: “Notice. Adjust. Tell someone if it does not shift.”

EXIT TICKET “Write one adjustment you might try and one person or number you would use if it did not help.”

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: RP2 Domain Vignettes (four, fictional), Impact Map (W-P2), Two-Week Experiment card, Help Routes card, Question Box.

- ☐ Fictional vignettes only. Ask no one for their hours or feelings. No self-harm methods or suicide statistics.
- ☐ Never say “you are addicted.”

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “What is the difference between choosing to use an app and feeling pulled by it?”
- 2** “How can a friend notice a pattern without judging?”
- 3** “When is ‘adjust it myself’ enough, and when is it time to tell someone?”

FUN BOOST Map Swap (calm). Groups trade maps and add one adjustment the first group missed.

LEVEL-UP Design brief. One page on a well-being feature for a made-up app.

DIFFERENTIATE Use a labeled Impact Map and two vignettes; oral answers are fine.

FAMILY CARD Ask: “Which app is hardest for you to put down? What would help?” If your teen seems down or hopeless, involve the counselor or doctor; 988 by call or text.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You are not in trouble, and it is not your fault.”
- “I want to help, and I will tell you exactly who I need to talk to.”
- “I can’t keep this secret. I need to bring in people who can help.”
- **Do not say:** “You’re just addicted.” Do not diagnose.
- “Everyone feels like that.” “Just put it down.”
- Do not ask for a method or detail.

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: immediate risk of self-harm: stay with the student, follow district protocol, call or text 988 or 911. Tell your counselor or designated person the same day; follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.